that they could keep the food price nominal. I wanted to replicate it in Mahendragiri, but there stood in the way a forest rule that prohibited introduction of fruit-bearing trees into forest land. Blame it on my ignorance on environmental matters, I never understood the logic that banned the introduction of only fruit-bearing trees while it did not stop planting of any other species, which could well be more invasive in nature.

There was nobody stopping me from doing the coconut planting, but just that I was aware of the rule. I decided to take the risk and assigned Thangaraj to get 5,000 coconut palms planted on the campus. More than a thousand of them grew up robust. Along with them, those from the three lakh saplings which grew to become trees formed a new canopy for the campus.

Those who have been flying down from the direction of Chennai to Trivandrum would know—if they looked at the right spot before landing—how Mahendragiri, which once looked like a patch of brown and sparse green at the tail end of the Western Ghats, is now a tuft of lush green. Dhawan, a nature lover who learned the nomenclature of virtually every tree in Mahendragiri from his botanist wife, would appreciate us every time he peeped out of the aircraft window after taking off from Trivandrum.

The greenery came with its share of animals. We were all for preserving the biodiversity, but snakes and leopards started giving us the creeps. Leopard sightings were not rare, snakes were aplenty. In the cold nights, especially when it rained, the slithery creatures took refuge in a tunnel we had dug to draw cables from the test stand to the instrumentation building, which was at an elevation, about 150 m away from the stand. There were instances of our workers pulling at a snake, mistaking it for a cable, and having a narrow escape from the hissing serpents.

Once I was travelling uphill in an open jeep with my left leg resting on the vehicle's side step. As the jeep was slowly taking a right turn, a long, black snake shot itself up from the ground. For a moment, it appeared to have been standing on its tail, its menacing hood at the level of my knee. I froze. After driving me to safety, the driver told me that it was a king cobra, probably the most venomous snake in the Western Ghats.